



Indian Government Takes the Open Source Route

The Indian Government has recently proposed to go the open source way in its e-governance projects, and the Department of Information Technology has issued a Draft Policy in this regard. The move has been welcomed by the IT industry. However, some implementation issues need to be addressed. LFY reports.

The Indian Government has been talking of systems based on open source for a long time, but these intentions are finally beginning to be put into practice now. According to a latest draft policy on e-governance, all new projects must work on open source operating systems only.

The draft 'Policy On Device Drivers For Procurement Of Hardware For e-Governance' states that the, "Government of India (GOI) endeavours to provide e-governance services, which are technology-neutral, cost-effective, interoperable and vendor-neutral. The GOI Policy on open standards is a step towards meeting this objective in the development of e-governance applications." The policy will be applicable in all new e-governance projects, as well as in existing ones.

The idea behind the draft

While implementing open source, device drivers for all General-Purpose Operating Systems (GPOSs) are, often, not available. "Hence, to empower the implementation of e-governance projects, there is a need for a policy from the GOI for the procurement of computers and associated peripherals, with neutrality to all general-purpose OSs," states the draft.

The draft clarifies the reason for covering both computers and peripherals. According to the document, most parts of the computer generally work with recent stable versions of both Windows and Linux operating systems. However, some devices, both internal (Web-cams, inbuilt sound systems and speakers) and external (like printers, scanners) may require drivers; the policy has to be applicable to them also. Hence, both computers and peripherals are covered in the policy, to ensure the proper working of the complete computer system.

What OEMs need to comply with

The Department of Information Technology has demanded the following from Original Equipment Manufacturers (OEMs):

1. Computers should be capable of running on all GPOSs.
2. OEMs should provide drivers for computers and peripherals, which are capable of functioning on all GPOSs.
3. Drivers for GNU/Linux (one of the GPOSs) should satisfy any of the following conditions:
 - The source code, build procedure and installation instructions for the drivers must be made available as per any of the Open-Source Software (OSS) licences listed. Using these drivers, computers and peripherals must be operational with the latest stable Linux kernel. Drivers compliant with these conditions are then expected to work in any of the Linux distributions.
 - The source code, build procedure and installation instructions for the drivers must comply with LSB 3.0 or higher versions, and be accepted by any of the Linux distributions. This compliance is opted for because the current stable version of Debian (Version 6.0 Squeeze) is compliant with LSB version 3.2, and not LSB version 4.0
 - In case only binaries are made available for the drivers, then they should be Linux-compatible; in addition, kernel-dependent binaries must adhere to the specifications of the latest stable Linux kernel.

As mentioned above, the adherence to any one of the three conditions is sufficient when considering the Linux OS. The reason cited for this is, as follows: "The source code of the device driver for the Linux Operating System is made available through two approaches, (a) under open source licences, and (b) LSB compliance, as indicated in the policy. The binaries